

Bluff

YOUR WAY THROUGH

Photoshop

Photoshop is all around us, at least at the *Digit* office. Some of us know how to use it a little bit, and many of us have seen that it is a powerful and fascinating tool—and have begun to ‘learn’ Photoshop. How far the learners have gotten is another matter altogether—but these people try to portray the image that they ‘know’ Photoshop. Here are some terms they throw at us.

Unsharp Mask: In order to bring out the details, most scans need to be sharpened. For this, most pros use Unsharp Masking. There are three parameters in the Unsharp Mask filter: Amount, Radius and Threshold. Threshold deals with levels of tonal separation. The Radius is the amount of sharpening you want. The Amount controls how effective your choice of Radius will be.

Didn’t get all that? Well, we didn’t either!

Blending Modes: These need two or more layers for any effect to work. You need at least two layers to blend together. A layer with a blending mode specified will blend with all other colours from layers underneath it. Photoshoppers call those original layer colors the base colours. The colours on the top layer are called the blend colors. The result is called the result colour.

Texture Mapping: This is a favourite of wannabe Photoshoppers. They often say something that sounds like the following: “I’ve been having problems with using texture maps in my renderings. I’m trying to render a brick building using a texture map, but when it renders, I get these weird patterns all over my image. I’ve tried to increase the actual scale of the text-map, that didn’t work. I tried to increase the size of the tiling, that didn’t work. It happens for every image map I use for brick. It’s getting frustrating...”

Just throw something like that at someone while looking frustrated, and they’ll think you’re a Photoshop pro!

The DVD Dude

April 1, 2005: We had a new recruit join us this month. Ishan, a soft-spoken, polite boy from UP, who did his Masters in Information Technology from Melbourne, Australia, was hired to take over the DVD and CD process, and also to write stories.

Sachin, our Executive Editor, hit him with the good news first: “No articles to write this month!” That brought a broad smile to his face—he thought he had time to settle in, get a feel for the place, get to know people. He was wrong!

April 2, 2005: Perhaps a day that will haunt Ishan for a lifetime. He had a meeting with Sachin and Raaabo (Robert). Raaabo informed him that the May 2005 DVD deadline was four days away. He took it well, all things considered, and all we needed were smelling salts to get him back to reality.

April 4, 2005: We were all awoken from our Monday morning slumber by a shrill scream, and subsequent sobbing. We found Ishan with his head in his hands: the screen before him said, “This page cannot be displayed”. The Internet connection was down—which is something Ishan will have to get used to. Like the rest of us have, over the years...

April 7, 2005: It’s amazing how mean we can be at times. We purposely didn’t tell Ishan he’d have tons of help from seasoned *Digit* veterans, helping him discover the secrets of the trade. Finally, a day before his deadline, help flowed in from everywhere, and Ishan was amazed to see the impossible become possible: the DVD was done on time.

Ishan smiles his soft smile as he sums it up: “At *Digit*, Internet access may be fleeting, but friends are made for life!”

DIGIT DIARY

Project suggests that Americans are learning to live with spam. Basically, the data suggests that Americans are tolerating spam better than they used to. And what’s true of Americans could well be true for people everywhere.

The news out of the Pew survey is this: “Compared to a year ago, fewer e-mail users now say that spam is undermining their trust in e-mail, eroding their e-mail use or making life online unpleasant or annoying.”

“It’s one of the annoyances in life that you eventually resign yourself to,” Pew Internet chief Lee Rainie told *The Washington Post* in an interview.

So is spam gradually becoming just another background distraction? After all, humans are talented at filtering out chronic distractions. We did it with the daily rush hour, the annoyance of overhearing strangers’ cell phone conversations, and the threat of nuclear annihilation. Now, the Pew survey says, we’re doing it with spam.

The findings are in contrast with the fact that over half the Americans now say they “trust e-mail less” because of spam.

The survey is not really groundbreaking—after all, given the fact that spam is only increasing despite all the efforts to control it, what else would people’s reaction be except to get used to it?

SMELL AND TASTE

Expect More From Movies

Sony was recently awarded a patent for a technology that could conjure up smells, tastes and other sensations in the

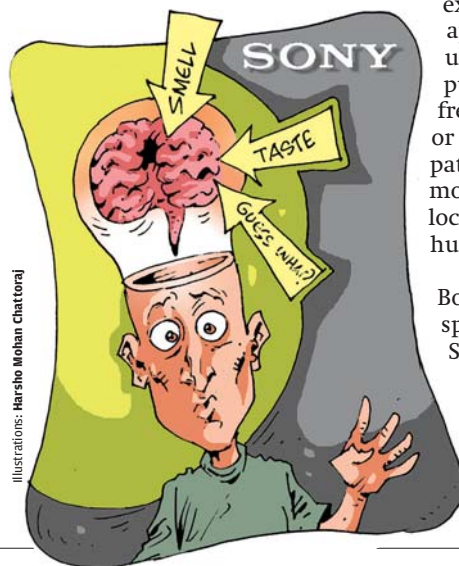
brains of movie-goers. Specifically, the patent covers “a method for generating sensory data onto the human neural cortex”. The patent describes using “ultrasonic transducers” to stimulate neural activity in particular areas of the brain, causing the person to experience smells and tastes as part of the cinematic experience.

The technology is outlined in the patent in this way: “Changes in the neural firing timing induce various sensory experiences, depending on the location... the system induces

recognisable sensory experiences by applying ultrasonic energy pulsed at low frequency in one or more selected patterns on one or more selected locations of the human cortex.”

Elizabeth

Boukis, a spokeswoman for Sony Electronics, described the invention as “prophetic”, *New Scientist* reports. “It was based on



Illustrations: Harsho Mohan Chatterjee